Status and handoff – ancient-texts translations

> **The first file a new session reads after `translation-guidelines.md`.** It says where the work stands and how to
> continue. **Keep it current:** every session that finishes a run, settles a decision or changes the plan updates it
> in the same commit.

Last updated: 2026-10-21 (Round 2, runs 5–7 in parallel in Claude Cloud; run 5 done).

1. Starting a session (local or Claude Cloud)

1. **Sync with `main`** (a resumed cloud session wakes up on an old checkout: the session operator's report says so).
2. **Restore the git-ignored sources:** most raw sources are not in git, since the repo is public (guidelines §8).

```
python3 -I tools/sources_sync.py status          # what is missing (work tier
python3 -I tools/sources_sync.py fetch           # restore it (about 5–15 min
python3 -I tools/sources_sync.py verify          # compare with the copies th
```

   - `FAILED … blocked by the network allowlist? host X`: that host must be added to the cloud environment's
     allowed domains, which only the user can do (claude.ai UI). Tell the user; continue with what you have.
   - `pdftotext is not installed`: `apt-get install -y poppler-utils` (or ask the user to add it to the environment's setup script).
   - `CHANGED`: the online edition changed since we used it (eBL and ORACC are living editions). Don't silently
     rebase a finished translation on it: note it in the project's `project.md` and tell the user.
   - Known on 2026-10-21: eBL changed **Atra-ḫasīs MB "Priv"** (`eBL/Atrahasis-MB-Priv/`) since the flood corpus used
     it (`CHANGED`): compare the new reading edition with `סיפורי-המבול-המסופוטמיים/4-נוסחי-מבול-אכדיים-נוספים/` and
     note what moved. Lenzi 2023's PDF always shows `CHANGED` (the repository re-stamps it); its text is identical.
   - The archive tier (`--all`) needs downloads from archive.org, which redirects to changing hosts
     (`dn….archive.org`): with a "Limited" allowlist they fail. It is not needed for translating.

3. **Read** `translation-guidelines.md` in full, then this file, then the plan (`curated-translation-candidates.md`,
   "Round 2 plan"), then the corpus you will work in (`corpus.md`, `renderings.md`, the `project.md` files).

2. Pace (guidelines §5.1)

- **Local sessions:** one sub-agent at a time (the user's quota).
- **Claude Cloud:** a special allowance, so no quotas are expected. Work at full speed, and run **independent runs in**
  parallel (different corpora). Inside one long text, keep the sequential translator chain. If a limit is hit, record
  it in §5.1 of the guidelines and fall back to one at a time.
- **Commit and push to `main` often:** after every finished section, not only at the end of a run. A cloud VM can be
  reclaimed, and a session can end; work that is pushed survives. Never commit `docs/` at the repo root (the RTL editor
  regenerates it; the user commits it).

3. What is done

All of it is a **first draft**: complete, verified by script, three review passes, but not yet reviewed by the user.

Corpus	Projects	Lines	Verify with
סיפורי-המבול-המסופוטמיים/	Atra-ḫasīs I–III, Gilg. XI 1–208, the Sumerian Flood Story, the other Akkadian versions, Berossus + Abydenus, flood references	(see corpus.md)	per project (see corpus.md)
סיפורי-הבריאה-המסופוטמיים/	1 Enūma eliš I–VII; 2 the creation and Eden companions (7 texts); 3 Bird and Fish; 4 Enki and the World Order	2,828	1-אנומה-אליש/verify.py, 2-.../verify.py, sumerian_tools.py
חוקים-ובריתות/	1 Esarhaddon's Succession Treaty; 2 Hammurabi (§66–99 missing in the base text); 3 Eshnunna; 4 MAL A; 5 Lipit-Ištar; 6 Ur-Namma; 7 MAL B	6,731	laws_*.py
אפוס-גילגמש/	SB I–X, XI 209–328, XII; the OB tablets	3,217	verify.py --strict
ספרות-החכמה-והצדיק-הסובל/	1 Ludlul I–V; 2 the Babylonian Theodicy	822	wisdom_tools.py verify
קינות-על-ערים/	1 the Lament for Ur; 2 the Curse of Agade (OB + Ur III)	763	lament_tools.py verify --strict
בניין-המקדש/	1 the Gudea Cylinders A–B	1,300	temple_tools.py verify GU --strict
העולם-התחתון/	1 the Descent of Ištar (SB + NA); 2 Inana's Descent	599	netherworld_tools.py verify IS --strict, ... verify IN --strict

Every finished translation has a print stub in הדפסה/ (guidelines §7.4). Each corpus has a parallels-index.md
with its key findings at the top.

4. What is next

The user paused the work after Round 2, run 4 (2026-10-20), and resumes it by starting the next session. The
remaining runs of the Round 2 plan (curated-translation-candidates.md):

Run	Texts	Base text	New corpus
5	**The Descent of Ištar** + **Inana's Descent to the Netherworld**	eBL (Ištar); ETCSL 1.4.1 + ORACC (Inana)	the netherworld: **done (first draft), 2026-10-21**, העולם-התחתון/
6	**Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta** + **the Sargon Birth Legend**	ETCSL 1.8.2.3 + ORACC; King 1907 (public domain) or a newer open edition	Gen 11 (the confusion of tongues) and Exod 2
7	**OB love lyrics** + **Sumerian proverbs** (a selection) + **OB letters** (a selection)	ORACC AkkLove / SEAL; ETCSL 6.1; ORACC/CDLI letters	everyday voices

Runs 5, 6 and 7 are independent (different corpora): in the cloud they can run in parallel, each as its own
coordinator with its own sequential translator chain. Each run is briefed as in §5 below.

5. The run brief (how every run so far was briefed)

A coordinator (one agent per run) gets this brief, adapted to its texts:

- **Read** translation-guidelines.md in full (binding; the translators too, with the ★ rules of §5.2 in their
  brief); STATUS.md; sources-registry.md before securing sources, tools.md before writing a tool; the plan row; the newest corpora as models for
  structure and tools (בניין-המקדש/ with temple_tools.py, קינות-על-ערים/ with lament_tools.py, ספרות-החכמה-והצדיק-הסובל/ with wisdom_tools.py, the creation corpus's sumerian_tools.py and translator-brief--sumerian.md). The existing corpora's renderings are binding for shared names, formulas and
  terms; for the still-open cross-corpus choices (§6) follow the most recent corpus and flag conflicts.
- **Both purposes (guidelines §1):** the Bible comparison (with the echo-control tags and check_bible_quotes.py)
  and "the soul of the ancients", equal in standing: the **הערות** explain the text on its own terms, even where
  there is no biblical parallel.

- **Process:** the §5 workflow. Create the corpus folder (`corpus.md`, `renderings.md`, `parallels-index.md`, one
  project folder per text). Record every new source per §2.2 and §4, add its recipe to `sources/fetch-recipes.tsv`
  if it is git-ignored and run `tools/sources_sync.py snapshot`, and add new hosts to `domains.txt`. Fix the
  renderings before drafting. Draft unvocalized and plene. Translators as sub-agents, each with the guidelines, the
  renderings, a translator brief and an exact line range; the coordinator merges their proposals into the renderings
  between translators. Three review passes; `translation.rtl.md` generated by script and verified identical to the
  `>` lines; `check_bible_quotes.py` on every file; translators print every verse before quoting it; print stubs.
- **Finish:** record what was learned where the guidelines' top box says (sources → `sources-registry.md`, tools
  → `tools.md`, decisions and false friends → §6.7, a lesson → one line in §5.2 + its story in `history.md`, a
  changelog line in `history.md`); update the plan row and this file; `git add` only its own files (never `-A`, never `docs/`,
  `claude-sessions/`, `__pycache__/` or git-ignored content); commit ("Ancient-texts translations: ...") and push.
- **Report:** what was translated and verified; key findings for the Bible; what the texts show of the ancient
  mind; open decisions for the user; anything skipped or failed.

6. Open decisions for the user

Each `project.md` lists its own. These cross corpora, so they matter most:

Decision	Now	Alternatives / where
Inana's name	אִינַנָּה (creation, laments, temple)	אִינַאנָּה (laws corpus)
The *me* (the divine powers and offices)	הַ־מָה (creation 3–4, laments, temple)	הַכֹּחוֹת הַנִּשְׁגָּבִים (flood corpus)
Bird	צִפּוֹר (Bird and Fish)	creation project 2 has עוֹף in Enki and Ninḫursaĝa 18 and the Song of the Hoe 83: align?
šiptu "incantation"	קֶסֶם (wisdom)	חֶבֶר (Deut 18:11), recommended by the coordinator
Bitumen	(Gudea)	חֵמָר (Gen 11:3) or כֹּפֶר (Gen 6:14, the flood corpus)
Gudea against earlier corpora	שורמן, הנכונה, רכב, ברכה	בניין-המקדש/1-גליליות-גודאה/project.md (see ברוש, אמת, רץ, תפילה)
Sumerian *uĝ₃* "people"	עָם (laments)	הָאֲנָשִׁים (creation)
kur (the netherworld)	הָאָרֶץ (= *erṣetu*; netherworld corpus)	אֶרֶץ / הַר "highland, foreign land" in the other Sumerian corpora (correct there: another sense)
sukkal / *šukkallu*	וְזִיר (creation, temple, netherworld)	שַׂר (Gilgameš VIII)
uznu / *ĝeštug₂* in "set the ear"	אֹזֶן (netherworld: the literal image)	בִּינָה (Gilgameš default)
ḫarrānu / *ḫar-ra-an*	אֹרַח (Gilgameš, netherworld)	דֶּרֶךְ (laments)
kabattu	כָּבֶד (wisdom, netherworld)	רוּחַ (Gilgameš)
ur₄ "pluck"	קָטַף (netherworld)	check the creation corpus (אָסַף?)

The decisions settled earlier (2026-10-18) are in the Gilgameš renderings §12, חוקים-ובריתות/corpus.md and the flood corpus renderings.